

Running a Grounded assessment

The facilitator's script — from first email to delivered verdict

"The facilitator's job is not to have opinions about the answers. It is to protect the honesty of the intake, surface the disagreement without naming who disagreed, and let the evidence speak. Do that, and the verdict runs itself."

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS

A word-for-word runbook for one person to run a full Grounded assessment without software — the emails to send, the words to say, the failure modes to catch, and how to turn independent answers into a Fault Line Report and a verdict using nothing but a spreadsheet. Read it once before your first session. Keep it open during.

THE FIVE STAGES OF AN ASSESSMENT

- 1 Scope — agree the Investment Statement**
One sponsor, one sentence, before anyone else is involved.
- 2 Intake — each role answers alone**
Private, 20 minutes, no conferring. This is where honesty lives or dies.
- 3 Aggregate — build the report before the room**
You, a spreadsheet, an hour. Verdict and fault lines ready before anyone meets.
- 4 Session — open on the disagreement**
90 minutes. Start from the fault lines, never from a blank canvas.
- 5 Deliver — verdict, debt register, expiry date**
The one-page output, and the clock that starts ticking.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN — THE TWO THINGS THAT MUST BE TRUE

Do not schedule anything until both hold. First, there is a **live investment decision** — real budget, real timeline, a board or sponsor who will actually decide. Grounded run on a hypothetical produces hypothetical answers. Second, the sponsor accepts that **the verdict may be "not yet."** If they have already decided to proceed and want validation, decline — you are being asked to launder a decision, not test one.

STEP 1.1 · AGREE THE INVESTMENT STATEMENT WITH THE SPONSOR

A 20-minute call with the sponsor alone. The whole assessment is answered against one sentence, so it must exist before intake. Walk them to it — don't accept the first draft, which is always too vague.

SAY THIS

"Before anyone answers anything, I need one sentence from you. Fill in the blanks: We are investing — so that — can —, measured by —. If you can't complete it, that's our first finding — and it's a common one. Take your time."

CATCH THIS — THE MEASURE

If the measure is "efficiency," "insights," or "productivity," push once: "measured by what number, moving from what to what?" If they still can't, the statement is not ready — and neither is the investment. Record it and continue anyway; the gap is the point.

CATCH THIS — THE AMOUNT

Sponsors often stall here because they genuinely don't know the cost yet — that's not a reason to make one up. Say: "The amount doesn't need to be precise. A ceiling, a magnitude, even 'not yet costed' all count." If they land on "not yet costed," don't treat it as a failure to complete the exercise — log it immediately as **Debt Item Zero** on the Debt Register, before Block 1 is even asked. An organisation that cannot bound its own spend has told you something real in the first five minutes.

STEP 1.2 · PICK THE ROLES — FOUR TO SIX, NEVER MORE

You need one person per evidence slice, and each must be close enough to their blocks to answer from what exists, not what they hope. The default set:

ROLE	OWNS THE EVIDENCE FOR
Finance lead (CFO / FD)	Block 3 — unit economics
Technical / data lead (IT / OT)	Blocks 4, 5, 10 — build, data, ops
Operations / frontline lead	Blocks 1, 2, 7 — problem, value, adoption
Risk / quality / legal lead	Blocks 8, 9 — governance, evaluation
Sponsor / strategy owner	Block 6 — moat & strategy

THE RULE THAT PROTECTS THE WHOLE METHOD

Every role answers **independently, before anyone is in a room together**. If two people "just align first," you have lost the fault lines — the single most valuable thing the assessment produces. Say it explicitly in the invite and again at the top of intake.

STEP 2.1 · THE INVITATION EMAIL

Send individually — not as a group thread. A group thread invites people to compare notes, which is exactly what must not happen.

SEND THIS

"You've been asked to answer part of a readiness assessment for [investment]. It takes about 20 minutes and you do it alone — please don't discuss your answers with colleagues first. There are no right answers and nothing is attributed to you by name. One rule: a 'Yes' only counts if you can name the thing that proves it — the document, the dashboard, the person, the date. If you can't name it in a few seconds, the honest answer is 'Partially' or 'No'. That's not a failing — it's the finding."

STEP 2.2 · WHAT EACH ROLE RECEIVES

The Investment Statement at the top, then only the questions for the blocks they own plus the three gate blocks (everyone answers 3, 5, 7 — that overlap is what creates fault lines). Each question has three buttons — **Yes** **Partially** **No** — and a mandatory "Name it" text field. A Yes with an empty "Name it" field auto-converts to Partially. In a no-software setup this is a Google Form with required fields, or a printed sheet you collect.

THE EVIDENCE RULE, ENFORCED MECHANICALLY

This is the heart of it. The "Name it" field is not optional and not decorative. It is what makes the difference between an opinion survey and a diagnostic. If you are collecting on paper, physically check every Yes has a named artifact before you accept the sheet.

STEP 2.3 · THE LIVE DEMONSTRATION (BLOCK 5, QUESTION 1)

One question is never answered on a form — it is **demonstrated live**. For the anchor question (in manufacturing, the 2am Question), book 15 minutes with the data lead and ask them to actually pull the record while you watch. "Show me, for last Tuesday, on your screen." A Yes they can produce in front of you is real. A Yes they "could get to by Thursday" is a Partially. This single move catches more inflation than any other.

You can be optimistic about your opinion. You cannot be optimistic about a document that does not exist.

You now have independent answers. Before the group meets, you — alone, in a spreadsheet, in about an hour — turn them into three things: a score, a set of fault lines, and a verdict. This is the work that lets the session open on disagreement instead of a blank page.

STEP 3.1 · SCORE EACH BLOCK

Yes = 2 **Partially** = 1 **No** = 0. Where a block was answered by more than one role (the gates), take the **weighted** answer: the role closest to the evidence counts double. A gate fails on two or more No answers among its weighted answers. Max 6 per block, 60 total.

STEP 3.2 · FIND THE FAULT LINES

For every question answered by two or more roles, compare. Flag by severity:

SEVERITY	TRIGGER
Critical	Role closest to the evidence says No ; a senior role says Yes — on a gate block. Caps the verdict at Conditionally Grounded on its own.
Significant	A Yes / No split between any two roles on the same question.
Minor	A Yes / Partially or Partially / No split.

STEP 3.3 · ASSIGN THE VERDICT

VERDICT	CONDITION
Grounded	Score ≥ 48 , all three gates passed, no critical fault line.
Conditionally Grounded	Score 30–47, or any failed gate / critical fault line.
Ungrounded	Score below 30, or two or more failed gates.

BEFORE THE SESSION — THE CALIBRATION CHECK

Scan each role's sheet. If anyone answered 27+ of 30 as Yes, don't celebrate — flag it. Honest organisations don't score that way. In the session, spot-check two of their Yeses by asking them to name the artifact aloud. This is quality control, not accusation.

90 minutes, everyone in the room, verdict and fault lines already in hand. You are not collecting answers here — that is done. You are walking the group through what their own independent answers revealed.

0–10 min Open on the method, not the verdict

Restate the Investment Statement. Remind them answers were independent and unattributed. Do not reveal the verdict yet.

10–50 min Walk the fault lines, hardest first

Show the pattern, never the person. This is the core 40 minutes — scripted on the next page.

50–70 min Build the Foundation Debt Register live

Every No becomes a debt item: cost to close, named owner, deadline. Do it on screen, in front of them.

70–85 min Reveal the verdict — and what it means

Now say it. Tie it to the debt register and the 90-day expiry, not to a bare number.

85–90 min Assign owners and the re-grounding date

Every gate-debt item leaves the room with a name against it and a date.

THE ONE LINE THAT CARRIES THE WHOLE SESSION

SAY THIS, EARLY

"I'm not going to tell you who answered what. I'm going to show you the four places where this team sees the same investment differently. Those four places are the agenda. The question is never 'who was wrong' — it's 'why does the evidence look different depending on where you sit'."

WALKING A FAULT LINE — THE FOUR MOVES

- 1 Show the split, by role category**
"On data readiness, the roles closest to the data answered No. The roles further from it answered Yes." Never a name.
 - 2 Ask for the artifact, not the opinion**
"Can someone put the thing that proves Yes on the screen right now?" The room resolves it, not you.
 - 3 Let the silence do the work**
If no artifact appears, don't fill the gap. The absence is the finding. Wait.
 - 4 Convert it to a debt item and move on**
"So this is a No. Cost to close? Owner? Date?" Then the next fault line. Don't litigate.
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WHEN THE ROOM PUSHES BACK — WHAT TO SAY

THE SITUATION	YOUR MOVE
The most senior person overrides a No: "That's not right, we have that data."	"Then let's look at it — can we pull it up now?" If it appears, change the answer live. If it doesn't, it stays a No. The rule outranks the room.
Someone demands to know who answered No.	"I don't share that — and that protection is exactly why the answers were honest. Let's stay on the evidence, not the person."
The group wants to argue the scoring.	"The score isn't the point — the verdict is, and it's driven by the gates and the disagreement, not the total. Let's look at the gate that failed."
A gate fails and the sponsor wants to proceed anyway.	"You can — Conditionally Grounded means proceed with the debt priced in. What it doesn't mean is proceed as if the gap isn't there. Here's the cost to close it."
Everything scores high and it feels too easy.	Run the calibration check aloud: pick two Yeses and ask for the artifact on the spot. If they can't produce them, the score was inflated — and now the room sees it.

THE FACILITATOR'S CONTRACT — NEVER BREAK IT

Individual answers are never attributed in the room. Not once, not "just this to make a point," not even if the person volunteers themselves. The moment attribution enters, the next assessment's intake will be dishonest — because people will answer for the room, not from the evidence.

THE ONE-PAGE OUTPUT

Within 48 hours, send one page: the verdict stamped large, a short fault-line summary (by role category, never by name), the Foundation Debt Register with owners and dates, and the expiry date. No appendices, no raw scores unless asked. The verdict is the headline; the debt register is the action; the expiry date is what brings them back.

DO

- Lead with the verdict word, not the number.
- Give every gate-debt item a name and a date.
- State the re-grounding date explicitly — 90 days.
- Keep it to one page they can forward to a board.

DON'T

- Attribute any answer to any individual.
- Soften an Ungrounded verdict into "nearly there."
- Let debt items leave the room unowned.
- Present the score as if it were the result.

GROUNDING EXPIRES — SET THE RETURN BEFORE YOU LEAVE

The verdict is valid for 90 days. Before closing, put the re-grounding date in the sponsor's calendar. If the verdict was Conditionally Grounded, the re-grounding is where each debt owner reports closure — and it takes a fraction of the first assessment because the artifacts are already named. This is what turns Grounded from a one-off workshop into a standing instrument.

PRE-FLIGHT CHECKLIST — RUN BEFORE EVERY ASSESSMENT

- ☐ Live investment decision confirmed, and the sponsor accepts "not yet" as a possible outcome.
- ☐ Investment Statement written and agreed — all four blanks filled with something specific.
- ☐ Four to six roles named, each mapped to the blocks they own.
- ☐ Individual intake invites sent — not a group thread — with the independence rule stated.
- ☐ The anchor question booked as a live demonstration with the data lead.
- ☐ Aggregation spreadsheet ready with scoring, weighting, gate logic, and verdict bands built in.
- ☐ 90-minute session booked with all roles; verdict and fault lines prepared beforehand.
- ☐ Re-grounding date reserved in the sponsor's calendar before the session ends.

Protect the honesty of the intake, surface the disagreement without naming who disagreed, and let the evidence speak.